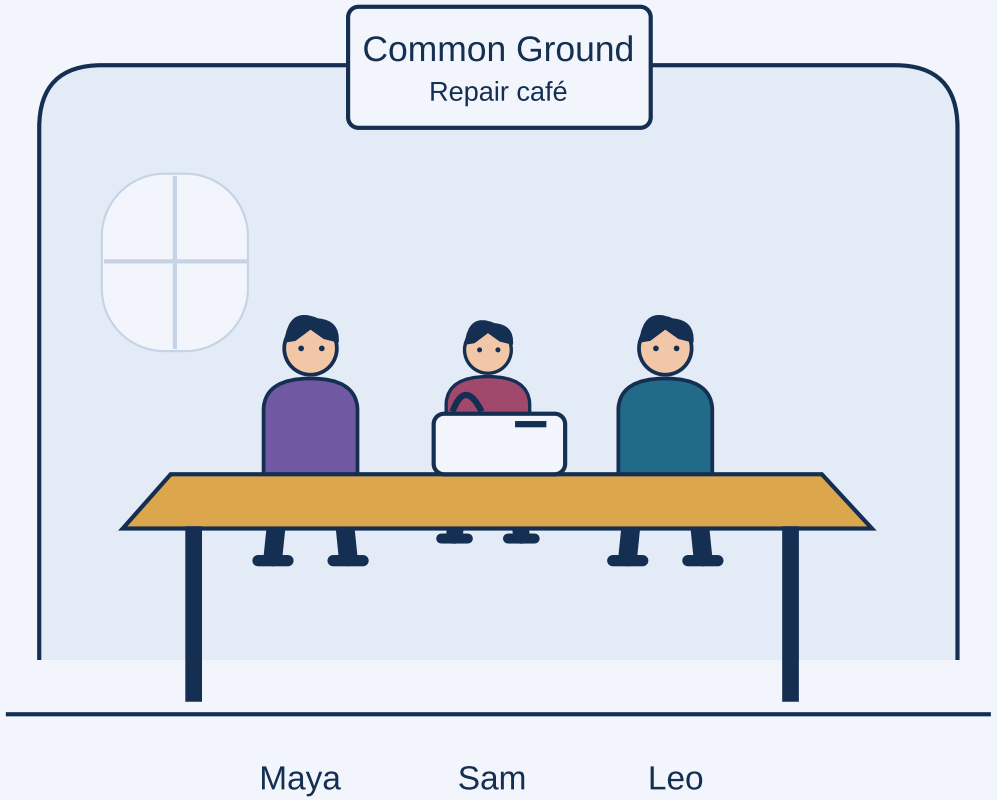
Chapter 8 · Story

“Anyone can join.” The form says otherwise.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



The invisible doorway · c08s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

How should the team investigate unequal access?

A Ask whether organizers consider themselves fair.

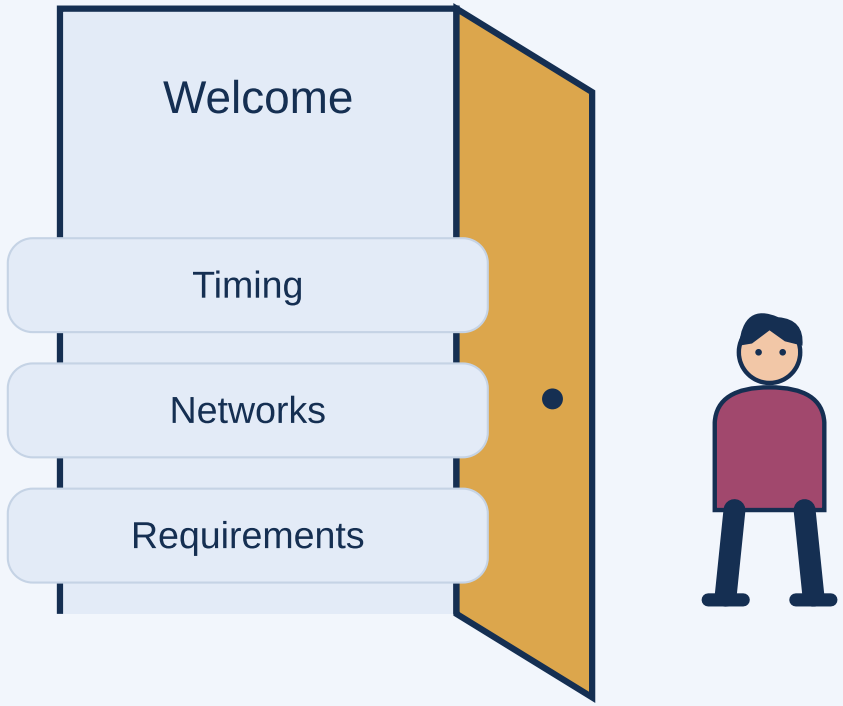
B Trace who can enter each stage and where people drop out.

C Add a fairness slogan to the poster.

Suggested answer: B. Tracing each stage can reveal access barriers that intentions and slogans miss.

Belief, feeling, and action are distinct.

- Stereotype: a generalized group belief.
- Prejudice: an evaluative attitude toward a group.
- Discrimination: unequal treatment based on group membership.

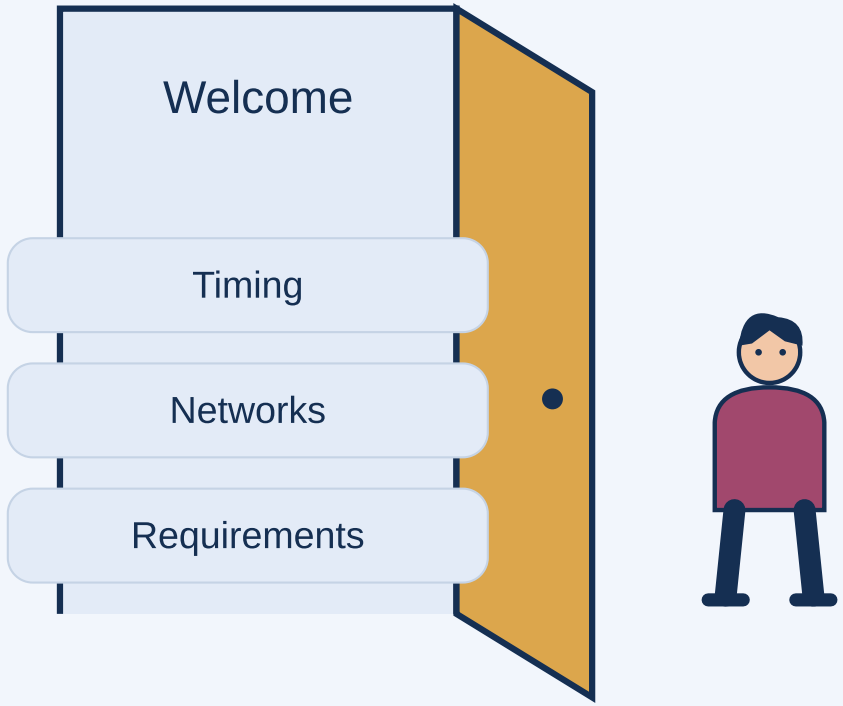


Good intentions do not remove every barrier.

Timing, networks, and requirements can restrict access.

Change the encounter and the structure.

- Use relevant, consistent criteria.
- Remove unnecessary access barriers.
- Support cooperation and meaningful participation.

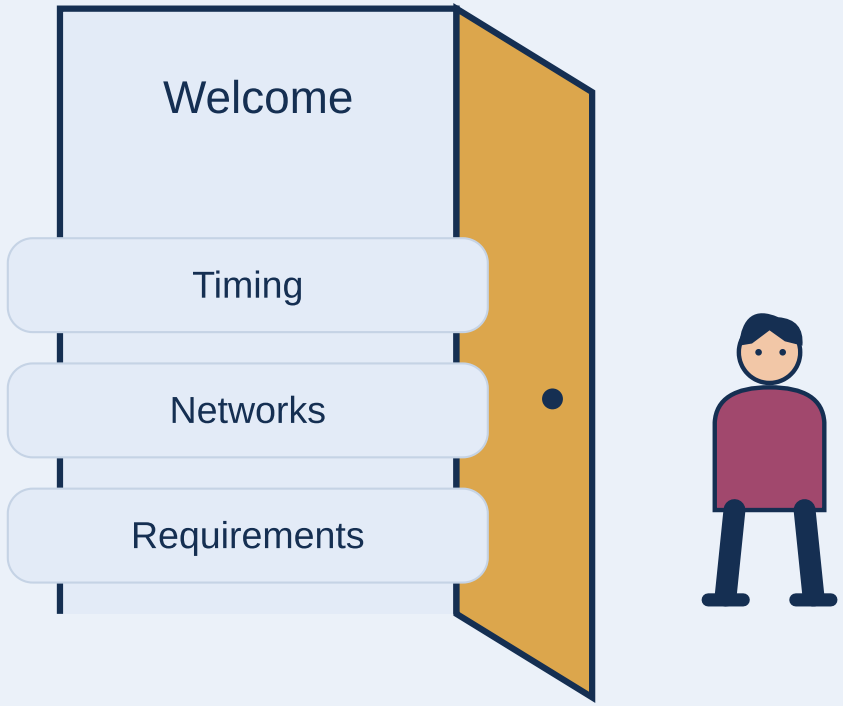


Good intentions do not remove every barrier.

Timing, networks, and requirements can restrict access.

What can we really conclude?

Explicit attitudes, implicit associations, and discriminatory behavior are different things to measure. A score on an implicit-association measure is not a complete diagnosis of a person’s character or a forecast of every action. Evaluate an intervention using meaningful behavior and access outcomes. Include follow-up and the experiences of people affected by the process. Interpret small samples cautiously and protect privacy. Investigating unequal access does not justify collecting unnecessary personal information.



Good intentions do not remove every barrier.

Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Friend referrals become an open skills-based application. How can improvement be assessed?

A Check whether organizers feel more inclusive.

B Compare the friendliness of form wording.

C Track applications, progression, and participation using relevant criteria.

Suggested answer: C. Applications, progression, and participation can show where barriers remain. Interpret those outcomes with context and privacy safeguards.

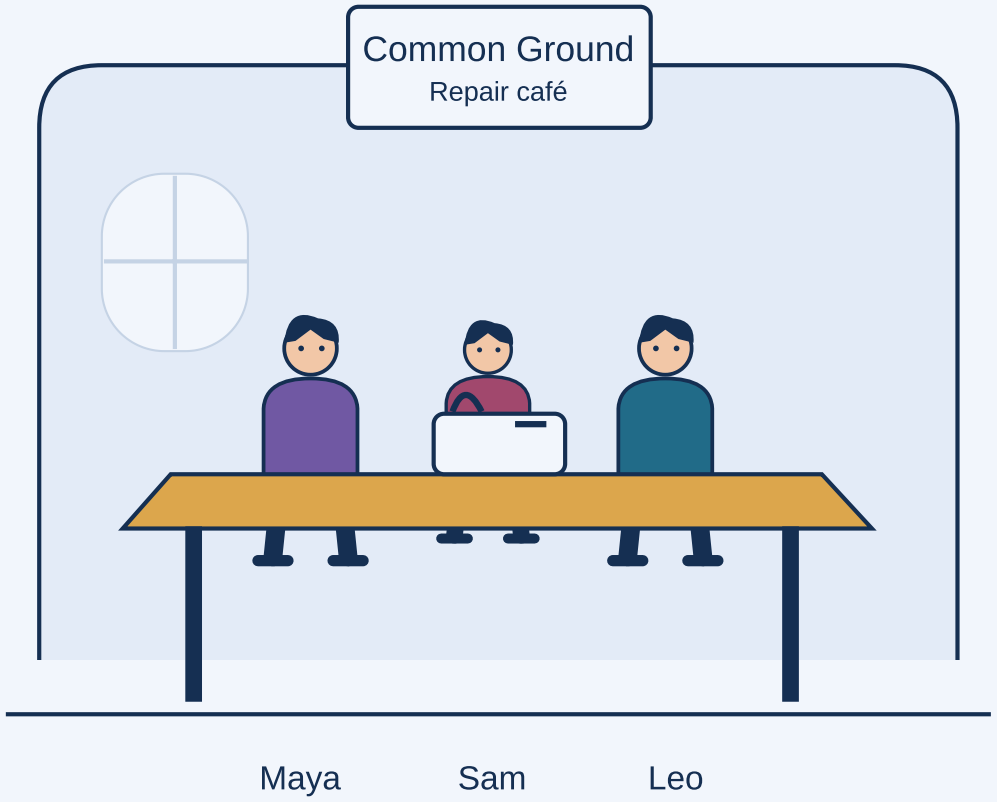
Close your notes. Explain it.

> Give an example of discrimination without an openly hostile statement.

> Why might a contact event leave unequal access unchanged?

1. An irrelevant requirement or restricted network can exclude a group without an openly hostile statement.

2. Contact can leave unequal access unchanged when decision power, incentives, status differences, or procedures remain the same.

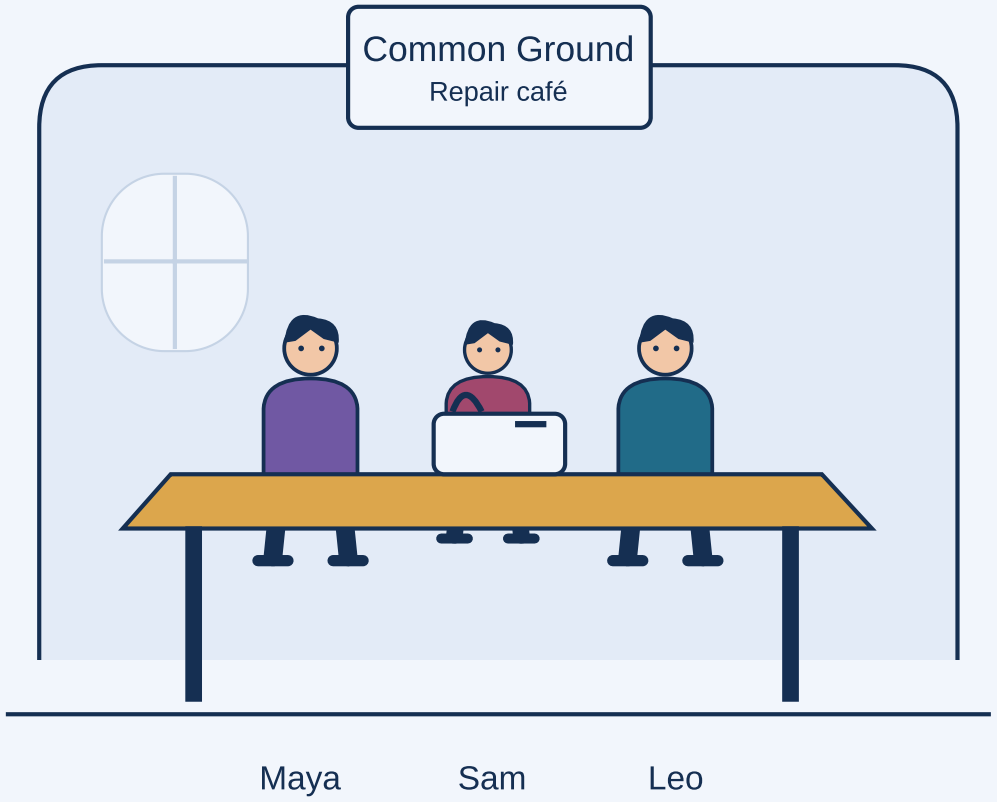


Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Review a process you are authorized to examine. Identify an unnecessary barrier, propose a change, and select a fair outcome measure without collecting unnecessary personal data.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.